

The FAQs below have been developed in response to questions and feedback received during industry engagement activities for this transition.

Process

There is no change to the current lodgement process for clients that do not use the import assessment email for lodgement. Biosecurity Industry Participants (BIPs) and COLS users will notice a system update, with a new consignment import option available: 'Unaccompanied Personal Effects (UPE)'.

A person in charge of UPEs taking responsibility for clearing their own goods.

No. From 10 August 2026, Australian Defence Force (ADF) Military consignment documentation must be lodged through Cargo Online Lodgement System (COLS), instead of email.

A lodgement can still be made by using cargo details instead of entry number.

Please refer to the Task card located on our [COLS support page](#).

No, UPE entries are now lodged with the department through COLS. Information is now captured in the information fields at the time of lodgement.

No. From 8 July 2026, Documentation will no longer be accepted by email for UPE clearances. Instead, you will receive an autoreply directing you to submit your lodgement through COLS.

Support materials are available to help you complete your lodgement, including a fact sheet and step-by-step guidance available on the [COLS support page](#).

Any lodgements submitted prior to Wednesday 8 July 2026 via the Import Assessment Mailbox will be assessed. Lodgements for UPEs will only be assessed through COLS from this date. Refer to the autoreply email you received.

No. Making a payment will be a step while lodging your documents through COLS. You do not need to inform us of making payment again.

No. Similar to other commodities requiring an import permit, there is no requirement to present a copy of the DAFF import permit. However, please ensure the permit number is identified in the COLS lodgement.

Currently, import documents lodged by email will be processed within 3 business day of receiving it. However, for import documents lodged via COLS, we will process urgent lodgements within 1 business day and non-urgent lodgements within 2 business days of receiving it. We may take longer to process lodgements if they need policy advice, you have provided incomplete or incorrect information, or if we need more information to continue the assessment. More information about our Client Service Standards can be found on our [Client service standards](#) page.

Clients can access COLS and submit documents for import assessment at any time however, the department's business hours are 6:30 am to 6:30 pm, Monday to Friday (excluding public holidays). Documents may be assessed outside business hours at industry request, subject to officer availability and industry acceptance of the cost. Please note where officer availability is limited for assessment outside business hours, perishable and some emergency services goods will be prioritised first.

Lodgement and timings

No. DAFF assessment cannot begin until Australian Border Force (ABF) assesses the UPEs.

A late lodgement occurs when documents for a sea freight shipment are submitted within 2 business days of their arrival. Where possible, documents should be lodged well in advance of arrival of the goods into Australia (between 5-7 days prior to a vessel's arrival for sea freight and 24 hours for airfreight) as this will allow assessment to occur and any identified concerns to be addressed prior to the discharge of goods.

Payment

An Account Holder with the department is a Biosecurity Industry Participant who has lodged documents with the department previously.

An AIMS Account Client is an entity that have been granted to receive services without paying fees up front.

These two terms are not the same.

Initial payment is required and must be paid prior to assessment.

If you're using a laptop or small screen and unable to move past the payment tab in COLS, it may be due to your screen's zoom level. To fix this:

- Ensure your display resolution is set as default 1920*1200
- Set your browser scale to 100%, or
- Use your mouse or trackpad to zoom out.

Once adjusted, the blue 'Next' button should become visible, allowing you to continue with the payment process.

Support

Yes. Alternatively, you can contact the department through COLS by using the Lodgement Reference Number (LRN) found on your lodgement email, or by submitting an enquiry.